

» FIFA WORLD CUP SPECIAL PRE-TOURNAMENT UPDATES



Pics: GETTY IMAGES

Hugo Ekitike, the Liverpool and France forward, will miss the 2026 World Cup after suffering a serious injury in his club's Champions League loss to Paris Saint-Germain, his national team coach Didier Deschamps confirmed. The 23-year-old crumpled in a heap holding his lower right leg, with a suspected ruptured Achilles tendon, during the first half of Liverpool's 2-0 quarterfinal second-leg defeat to European champion PSG.

« The Iranian team is coming for sure, yes. We hope that by then, of course, the situation will be peaceful. As I said, that would definitely help. But Iran has to come. Of course, they represent their people. They have qualified. The players want to play. I went to see them. They are actually quite a good team as well. And they really want to play, and they should play. Sports should be outside of politics now – FIFA president Gianni Infantino at CNBC's Invest in America Forum »



« Neymar is capable of getting back to 100 per cent. He is being assessed by the CBF (Brazil's Football Confederation) and by me, and he still has two months to show that he has what it takes to play in the next World Cup. Neymar has made, and continues to make, history in Brazilian football. He is a great talent, and it's only natural that people think he can help us win the next World Cup. I've said this several times, and it's very clear: I'll call up the players who are physically ready – Brazil coach Carlo Ancelotti to *L'Equipe* »

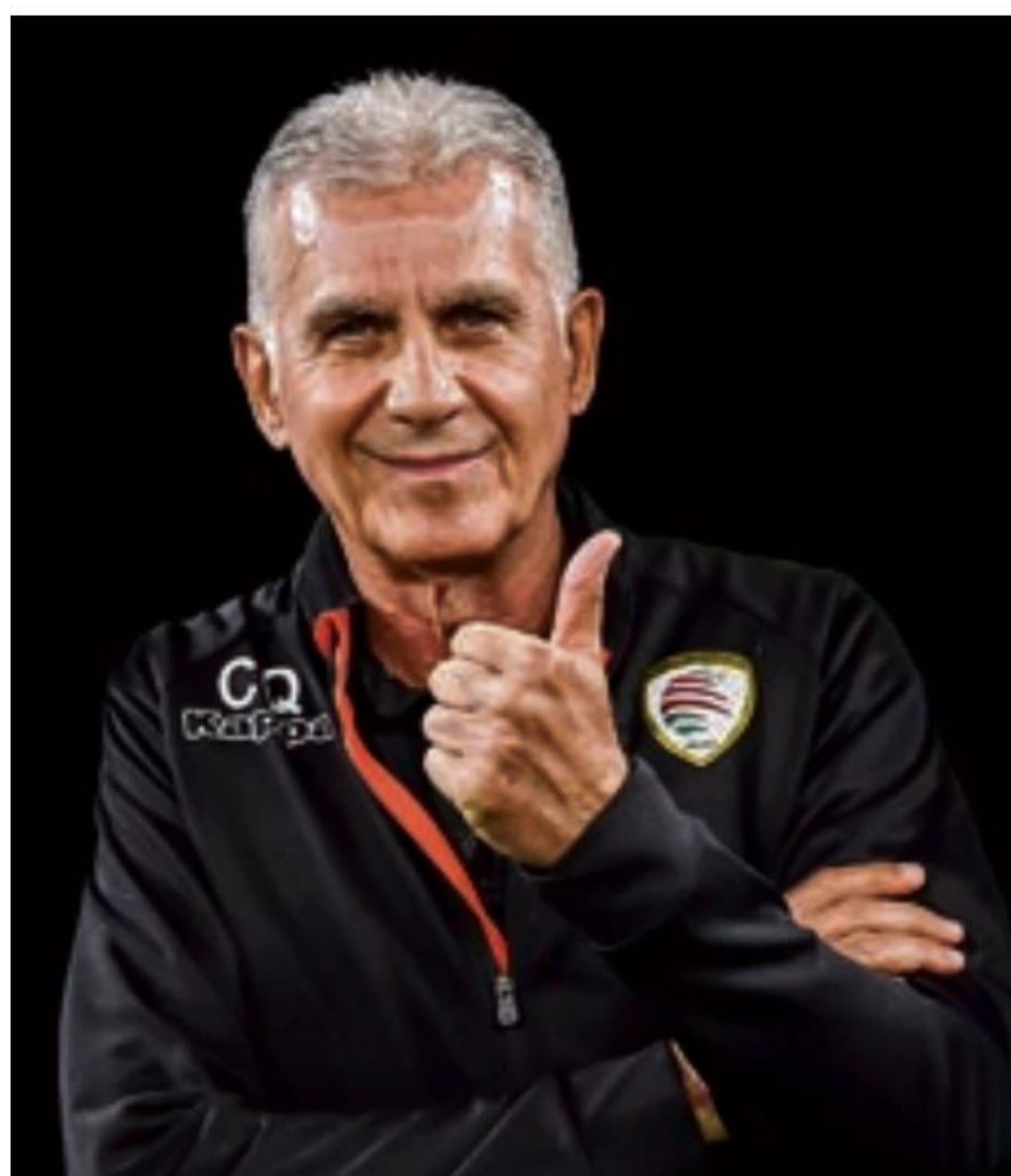


Cristian Romero's stint with Tottenham Hotspur this season could potentially have come to an end when he hobbled off during the Premier League match against Sunderland. The defender was inconsolable when he walked off, as his injury did not just threaten his league campaign but also put him in serious doubt as Argentina starts its FIFA World Cup title defence in the United States of America, Mexico and Canada later this year.



Not the perfect fit

Nike is investigating a design issue affecting several national team kits before the FIFA World Cup 2026. Bulging around the shoulder, seams was visible on shirts worn by teams including England, France and Uruguay during the international window. The American sportswear giant produces kits for a number of World Cup teams, including the United States and Canada, as well as Brazil, the Netherlands, and Croatia.



Carlos Queiroz, 73, is set to make his fifth consecutive World Cup appearance after being appointed Ghana's head coach. The Portuguese left his role as Oman coach last month after the side failed to qualify for the 2026 World Cup. He had led Portugal to the round of 16 at the 2010 World Cup and later coached Iran in the last three editions of the tournament, recording three wins in 13 matches.